

MICHAEL J. GIGANTE

Ph.D. Candidate in Political Science

Schar School of Policy and Government, George Mason University

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Comparative politics; political economy; quantitative and qualitative methods; public opinion; immigration and demographic change; party politics and institutions; and the politics of East Asia, with a focus on Japan.

EDUCATION

- | | |
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| Ph.D., Political Science
George Mason University, Schar School of Policy and Government
<i>Dissertation: "Contested Spaces: Immigration and Domestic Politics in Japan"</i> | 2021–2026 (expected) |
| Master of Law (LL.M.), Political Economy of East Asia
Kyushu University, Fukuoka, Japan | 2018–2019 |
| B.A., Asian History, Summa Cum Laude
CUNY – College of Staten Island, New York | 2010–2014 |

PEER-REVIEWED BOOK

Gigante, Michael, and Ming Wan. 2025. *Factional Politics in the Liberal Democratic Party: Explaining Change and Continuity in Japan's Economic Statecraft*. Elements in Indo-Pacific Security. **Cambridge University Press**.

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

- Gigante, Michael, and Justin Gest. 2025. "Gray Area: Population Aging and Immigration Attitudes in Japan." *PS: Political Science & Politics*.
- Gigante, Michael, Joshua Stone, Daniel Druckman, and Ming Wan. 2025. "The Rise and Fall of the Confucian Long Peace: A New Dataset for Analyzing Regional Conflict Management in East Asia (1598–1894)." *Journal of Conflict Resolution*.
- Gest, Justin, Michael Gigante, Neslihan Kaptanoğlu, Ian M. Kysel, and Lucas Núñez. 2024. "Migrant Rights Protections and Their Implementation in 45 Countries." *International Migration Review*.

INVITED CONTRIBUTIONS

- Gigante, Michael, Joshua Stone, Daniel Druckman, and Ming Wan. 2026. "The Lessons of the Long Confucian Peace." *Foreign Affairs* (online), May 6.
- Gigante, Michael, and Ming Wan. "Calculated Dependence: Party Politics and Ideological Shifts Driving Japan's Foreign Policy Behavior." Chapter in *Domestic Politics and the Management of Great Power Relations: Second Image Revisited*, edited by Steve Chan and William R. Thompson. In final review, under contract with **Routledge**.
- Gigante, Michael, and Hana Anderson. 2026. "Stabilizing Japan's Healthcare System: Proposals for New Funding Sources." Policy Report, The Asia Group / Amgen.

WORKING PAPERS

- Gigante, Michael. "Ghosts of Factions Past: Informal Network Coordination and Legislative Voting After the 2024 LDP Dissolution."
- Gigante, Michael. "Demographic Shock? What Information about Decline Does and Does Not Do to Immigration and Fertility Attitudes in Japan."

Gigante, Michael. “Geography, Demographics, and the Agency of Decline: Qualitative Evidence on Immigration and Fertility Attitudes in Japan.”

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

Gigante, Michael. “Immigration or Children? Testing Nationalist Backlash and Demographic Apathy in Japan.”

Correa-Cabrera, Guadalupe, Michael Gigante, and Rajendra Kulkarni. “Cartel Violence and Resource Competition in Mexico.”

FUNDING AND PARTNERSHIPS

Japan Foundation

October 2024 – April 2025

Selected as a Research Fellow and awarded \$20,000 to study Japanese public opinion on migration policy; conducted fieldwork and interviews in Tokyo, Gunma, and Fukuoka, in Japanese.

Ipsos Japan

2023

Research partnership to field a nationally representative survey experiment (n=1,000) on demographic information and immigration attitudes.

TEACHING

Instructor, R for Social Science Research

George Mason University

Designed and led reproducible R workshops (data wrangling, visualization, and simple causal designs) for graduate students and faculty.

Invited Lecturer, Graduate Methods Course

George Mason University

Presented a session on R Markdown and reproducible research workflows.

Teaching Assistant

Kyushu University

Master’s program in the Political Economy of East Asia.

Assistant Language Instructor, JET Programme

Fukuoka, Japan

Co-planned and co-taught English across grade levels and proficiencies in mixed-ability classrooms.

Private Instructor, English for Professionals and University Students

Individualized, needs-based instruction throughout graduate career.

RESEARCH & PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Graduate Research Assistant

September 2024 – June 2026

Prof. Guadalupe Correa-Cabrera, George Mason University. Research on immigration enforcement, human smuggling networks, and illicit cross-border flows; built data visualizations of migration and security trends.

Project Manager, Team Players Project

February 2024 – September 2025

George Mason University. Designed and implemented survey experiments on governance and institutional trust; managed data collection and quantitative analysis.

Project Manager, Migrants’ Rights Database Initiative

January 2021 – February 2024

Cornell University. Led a multi-year initiative building a global comparative database on migrants’ rights; recruited, coordinated, and synthesized assessments from a 90-person team of international legal experts.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Associate, The Asia Group

May 2024 – Present

Washington, D.C. Policy research on Japanese domestic politics, U.S.-Japan relations, energy, and pharmaceutical policy; U.S. electoral forecasting and quantitative analysis for client advisory.

Legislative Research Assistant, Office of Congressman Rob Wittman

Sept – Dec 2022

U.S. House of Representatives. Policy briefings on U.S.-China relations, Asia-Pacific security, and China's political economy.

Languages: English (native); Japanese (fluent – research, fieldwork, and interviews conducted in Japanese).

REFERENCES

Justin Gest (Dissertation Chair)

Professor, Schar School of Policy and Government, George Mason University. jgest@gmu.edu

Jack A. Goldstone

Professor, Schar School of Policy and Government, George Mason University. jgoldsto@gmu.edu

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Professor, Political Science, Texas Christian University. michael.strausz@tcu.edu

Ming Wan (Book Coauthor)

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